

Speed Disk. The first dialog box shows you a list of available drives. Select the drive which you want to defragment, and click on Settings. Click on 'Optimize swap file' to defragment the swap file. You can also arrange files by the file size, the date they were created, accessed, or used. These options should be selected only if you know which files should go where.

You can select specific files or use wildcard characters. This results in a customised and efficient defragmentation process.

For Windows XP, there are no direct options for setting such criteria, but you can manually add the filenames you want by clicking on

D r i v e Options. In the tabs named Files First, File Last, Files at End and Unmovable Files, you can add the file names with wildcards so as to place them accordingly.

Sort files according to how often they are accessed, when defragmenting using Norton Speed disk

Under Add File, an Open File dialog opens asking for files to be added—you can select multiple files at once. Finally click OK and then Start, to begin defragmenting.

You can do the same for other partitions as well, such as your Games partition, where you need maximum performance.

Ontrack SystemSuite: This suite is advanced and very user-friendly. It offers a wide range of features, such as DiskFixer, which scans your hard disk for any errors. Start the DiskFixer Wizard and select the drives you want to scan. At the bottom of the window, click on the Settings tab. Select all the tests and choose Duplicate, from the Crosslinks option, and then select Delete,

from the 'Lost Clusters' option. Select all the scans under Surface Scan, and click OK.

Back in the main wizard screen, select 'Automatically fix errors without asking me', 'Save Undo Information' and 'Scan disk surface for read errors'—this helps by doing a more thorough physical test of your hard disk. Click Next to see the screen where the fixer shows a complete map of your hard disk while it's checking. Since the disk surface scan has been selected, the time taken will depend on your PC's configuration.

Ontrack JETDefrag: Ontrack advises you to use DiskFixer before using JETDefrag. This is to ensure that no errors occur during the defragmentation process. Click OK, and select the drives you want to defragment. Click on Settings, and move the Space Consolidation slider to Maximum. This will eliminate slack space, and pack the files more tightly. Under 'Days until files become Rarely modified:' you can specify which files will be considered least accessed—if you specify the number of days as 60, then files not modified for 60 days will be considered as rarely used or modified.

In the option 'Days the files remain Frequently modified:', set the number of days that specify which files are considered frequently modified. These files will be placed at the start of the drive so as to quicken access to them. Click OK, and then Next. In the Warning dialog box, click OK to start the defragmentation process.

Do not open or run anything while defragmentation is on. After it's over, press Done and close the main window. Shut down Windows, and leave it off to cool after the heat produced by intense hard disk activity.

Always remember to perform these actions, no matter what utilities you choose, as regularly as possible. Doing this every 10 to 15 days will prolong the life of your hard drive, and also make a noticeable difference in speeds and access times for your applications and games.

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